

HEART OF THE CITY

An elegantly written and visually evocative overview of the Capital as it has evolved over the decades



DELHI THEN AND NOW

by DILIP BOBB AND NARAYANI GUPTA,

Edited by PRAMOD KAPOOR

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■ By Pavan K. Varma

Among the great cities of the world, Delhi must be the least written about. Indians are conscious of the cycle of time but have little time for the wheel of history. The citizens of Delhi take pride in this national proclivity for amnesia. Those who live in Hauz Khaz do not know who Allauddin Khilji was; nor do the residents of Safdarjung Enclave bother to find out how their "colony" got its name. Avalanched by our daily dose of municipal concerns, we take our ancient city for granted.

Delhi Then and Now is, therefore, a pleasurable antidote to our collective truce with ignorance. I say pleasurable because it will not burden you with a long tome on the city. Narayani Gupta's short piece on Delhi's history and Dilip Bobb's brief overview of the city's present are elegantly written and packed with information. For Gupta, a historian who has written a wonderfully erudite book on 19th-century Delhi, it must have been an effort to say so much in so little space. Bobb, a journalist-writer of great competence, brings into play the insight of an observer who has personally seen how much the city has changed in the last 60 years.

But the real strength of this book are the photographs. Pramod Kapoor, the meticulous editor of Roli Books, has done a commendable job of researching and editing the photographs. Many pictures of the city's recent past, especially those relating to Shahjahanabad and the making of New Delhi, have been published for the first time and constitute a magnificent chronicle in black and white. The city has changed so much that it is nothing short of a revelation to see how monuments and places looked like a hundred years



MARCH PAST: (Top) a photograph of a rehearsal of the royal procession at the Red Fort in 1911; celebrating Independence Day now



ago. The pictures of Delhi as it is today capture the bewildering variety and energy of the modern Capital. Several photographers have contributed, including Sondeep Shankar, with whom I worked on my book on the *havelis* of old Delhi.

Typical of Roli's oeuvre, this is a

lavishly produced book; the reproduction of the photographs is of international quality, and several double spreads delight with their panoramic sweep. For those who love Delhi, or are curious about what it looked like and how it has changed, this is a collector's item. ■